

Staff Onboarding Steps

Purpose

This document describes the end-to-end process for onboarding new staff members to CAL's operating environment. It covers account setup, role-based access, workspace orientation, daily operational habits, client data boundaries, and security expectations. The public-facing website is the client portal only; staff work in the internal operations system.

Before Onboarding

1. Confirm the person's intended role

Before creating any access:

- Confirm the person is staff, not a client.

- Determine the function they will serve:

 - Tax advisory

 - Accounting

 - Business permits and licensing

 - Document management

 - Operations and internal support

 - Reporting and compliance

- Decide whether the person is a full team member, contractor, or temporary role.

- Confirm reporting line: who will supervise or approve this person's access.

2. Define the minimum required access

- Use the principle of least privilege.

- Choose the smallest role that covers the required tasks.

- Do not assign broader permissions in advance "just in case."

- If responsibilities change later, adjust access explicitly.

3. Prepare the identity

- Use the person's legal name as it should appear internally.

- Use the person's work email address.

- Avoid shared or generic inboxes for staff accounts.

- Avoid reusing another person's existing account.

Step 1: Create the Staff Account

1.1 Where the account is created

Staff accounts are created in the internal operations system by an admin or designated account manager. The public website is not used to create staff accounts.

1.2 Required information

Gather the following before creating the account:

- Full legal name

- Work email address

- Employees or staff identifier, if applicable

- Department or functional area

- Supervisor or manager

- Intended role

Start date or access effective date
Reason for access request

1.3 Role selection

Assign only the role needed for the person's job.

Common role categories include:

Staff/Advisor — general operational access appropriate to consulting work.

Accounting — access relevant to accounting and financial records.

Permits/Documentation — access for permit and document workflows.

Reports/Read-only — for review and reporting use.

Admin — reserved for system administration and access provisioning.

1.4 Account creation checklist

Before saving the account:

- ☐ Name matches the person's official identity.
- ☐ Email is the correct work email.
- ☐ Role is the smallest role suitable for the job.
- ☐ No extra permissions were granted beyond the role.
- ☐ The account is not a copy of another person's account.
- ☐ Account creation is recorded internally with a brief note on why access was granted.

Step 2: Share Login Details Securely

2.1 Delivery rules

Send credentials only through a secure, approved channel.

Do not paste passwords, API keys, active session links, or temporary tokens into chat, email, public notes, or screenshots.

If your environment supports secure password delivery, use that method.

If no automated secure delivery path exists, share credentials verbally or through a protected internal channel, and confirm receipt.

2.2 What to tell the new staff member

How to reach the staff portal.

That the account is personal and must not be shared.

That any initial temporary password or activation step must be completed promptly.

Whether the staff member must change their password on first login.

Who to contact if login fails.

2.3 What not to do

Do not send credentials in the same message as the username if a secure separate channel is available.

Do not include credentials in onboarding emails that may be forwarded.

Do not screenshot the login screen with credentials visible.

Do not reuse a password pattern that is easy to guess or already known.

Step 3: First Login

3.1 Opening the staff portal

The staff member opens the staff portal link provided by their manager or admin.

The staff member signs in with their own account.

If the staff portal is reached from a website link, it should open the internal operations login page, not a shared public sign-in.

3.2 First-login verification

Ask the staff member to confirm the following after signing in:

- Profile name is correct.
- Email address is correct.
- Timezone is correct for their working location.
- Company/workspace context is correct.
- Language preference is set, if relevant.

If anything is wrong, correct it before the staff member begins real work.

3.3 Initial orientation tasks

Immediately after first login, the new staff member should:

- Open the staff operations guide.
- Locate and review My ToDos.
- Identify where tasks, customers, clients, projects, and documents are found.
- Identify the search bar and how to use it.
- Pin the modules used most frequently.

Step 4: Learn the Workspace

4.1 Opening the staff operations guide

Staff open the staff operations guide from the internal workspace.
The guide explains where to find customers, tasks, documents, invoices, permits, and reporting.
If the staff member does not know where the guide is, they should ask before guessing through unrelated menus.

4.2 My ToDos

Review My ToDos as the primary daily task list.
ToDos are used to track action items, follow-ups, and assigned work.
Each ToDo should have an owner, due date or target timeframe, and a brief description of the next step.

4.3 Search

Use search before creating new records.
Search for people, clients, companies, and documents before creating duplicates.
If search returns no result, confirm whether the item should exist first rather than creating another copy.

4.4 Pinning commonly used modules

Pin the workspace modules the staff member uses every day.
Typical pinned modules may include:
ToDos
Customers or clients
Projects or matters
Documents
Accounting or ledger screens, if part of the role
Invoices or billing, if part of the role
Permits, if part of the role

Step 5: Verify Access

5.1 Access test checklist

After account creation and first login, test access to the records the role should see:

- ☐ My ToDos are visible and assigned correctly.
- ☐ Customers or clients relevant to the role are accessible.
- ☐ Projects, matters, or engagements are accessible if applicable.
- ☐ Documents are accessible if applicable.
- ☐ Accounting or financial records are accessible only if the role requires them.
- ☐ Invoices or billing records are accessible only if the role requires them.
- ☐ The staff member cannot view another client's data they should not see.
- ☐ The staff member cannot access admin-only areas unless that is intended.

5.2 Handling missing access

If the staff member cannot access something required for the job:

- Do not use someone else's account to bypass the limitation.
- Request access through the manager or admin.
- Describe exactly which record, module, or action is blocked.
- Record the approval when access is granted.

Step 6: Practice Before Live Work

6.1 Use a safe practice environment

- If a training customer, test client, or draft record exists, use it for practice.
- If no training record exists, confirm with the manager before exercising real client data.
- Practice should not be done on live client records until the staff member has completed orientation.

6.2 Core practice flow

Practice the following sequence:

1. Find the client or customer record using search.
2. Open the correct customer or client workspace.
3. Add a note or task related to the record.
4. Assign the task to the correct owner.
5. Set or confirm the due date or next action.
6. Update status when the task is completed.
7. Close the loop with a short handover note if needed.

6.3 Practical practice scenarios

Examples of practice tasks:

- Create a follow-up task for a client matter.
- Add a note to an existing record.
- Locate a document attached to a client record.
- Mark a practice ToDo complete and record the outcome.
- Locate the client's current status and next step.

6.4 Go-live rule

- Do not work on live records until the practice step is complete.
- If uncertainty remains, ask before proceeding.

Step 7: Daily Work Habits

7.1 Morning checklist

At the start of the day:

- Open My ToDos.

Review overdue items first.
Review items assigned to you.
Review items awaiting your action or approval.
Identify today's priorities before opening unrelated records.

7.2 Before opening any financial document

Confirm the company or client context.
Confirm you are in the right customer or client record.
If a document looks unfamiliar, stop and verify before editing or acting on it.

7.3 Creating records

Search before creating.
Use the customer or client record as the anchor for related work.
Avoid creating duplicates of existing clients, projects, or documents.
If a new customer or client must be created, confirm it does not already exist.

7.4 Draft, review, submit

Draft first.
Review supporting documents and information before submitting anything.
Submit only when the record is complete enough to be meaningful.
If a record affects the client, confirm the client-facing impact before finalizing.

7.5 Closing the loop

Mark completed tasks as complete.
Leave a short handover or status note when handing work to another person.
Record next steps clearly so another team member can continue without starting over.

Step 8: Client and Data Boundaries

8.1 Where staff work

Staff work in the internal operations system.
The website remains the client-facing portal.
Staff should not treat the website as the place for internal operations work.

8.2 Client account access

Client accounts do not automatically receive access to the internal operations system.
If a client needs website portal access, that is prepared separately.
Client portal access should be limited to the client's own data.

8.3 Data separation expectations

Staff must not expose another client's data to the wrong person.
Staff must not use client-facing views to perform internal operations tasks that should happen in the operations system.
When in doubt about who should see information, assume the more restricted path until confirmed.

Step 9: When Something Does Not Match

9.1 Stop and identify the mismatch

If the operations system and the website dashboard show different information:
Stop work on the affected record.
Identify the exact mismatch:
Document ID

Customer or client name
Company
Time and date observed
Current status in each system
Error message, if any

9.2 Do not patch both systems

Do not edit both systems just to make them agree.
Do not assume either system is correct without checking the source of truth.
Corrections should happen in the system that owns the record.

9.3 Report the issue

Report to the operations lead with:

Who observed the mismatch
Which systems were compared
The specific fields or values that differ
Any error messages
The time the mismatch was noticed

Step 10: Common Troubleshooting

10.1 Cannot log in

Confirm the staff portal link is correct.
Confirm the username and password are entered correctly.
If the account was just created, confirm it has been activated.
If login still fails, contact the person who provisioned the account.

10.2 Cannot see expected records

Confirm the role matches the expected access.
Confirm the record belongs to the right company or client context.
Confirm the record has not been moved, archived, or restricted.
If still missing, request access review from the manager or admin.

10.3 ToDos not visible

Confirm the ToDo is assigned to the correct person.
Confirm the ToDo is not filtered by status or date range.
Confirm the staff member is looking in My ToDos rather than a different list.

10.4 Duplicate records

Search before creating again.
If duplicates exist, do not delete records arbitrarily.
Report the duplicate to the person responsible for data integrity.
Decide which record is correct before merging or cleaning up.

10.5 Website and operations system disagree

Treat this as a data issue, not a cosmetic one.
Do not silently edit both sides.
Escalate with the details in Step 9.

Step 11: Security Policies

11.1 Account rules

One person, one account.
No shared logins.
No account sharing to “save time.”
No borrowing another staff member’s session.

11.2 Credential rules

No passwords, API keys, session links, or tokens in chat, notes, emails, or screenshots.
No storing credentials in personal files that are not approved for that purpose.
Report lost credentials immediately.

11.3 Access discipline

Only request the access needed for the job.
Only grant the access needed for the job.
Review access when responsibilities change.
Remove access promptly when a person leaves or changes role.

11.4 Incident reporting

Report these immediately:

Lost or stolen device with access to the system
Suspected shared or compromised account
Unexpected access changes
Data shown to the wrong client or person
Any login or access anomaly that cannot be explained

Step 12: Offboarding

When a staff member leaves or changes roles:

Review current access.
Disable or adjust access according to the offboarding process.
Confirm whether any active tasks should be reassigned.
Confirm whether any client or project ownership should change.
Record what was changed and when.

Quick Reference

Onboarding sequence

1. Confirm role and least-privilege access
2. Create staff account in the operations system
3. Share login details securely
4. First login and profile verification
5. Learn the workspace, ToDos, search, and pinned modules
6. Verify access against expected records
7. Practice on a safe record before live work
8. Follow daily habits and data boundaries
9. Escalate mismatches instead of patching both systems
10. Follow security and offboarding rules

Main rules

Use one account per person.
Never share credentials.
Never bypass access limits with another person’s account.
Client access is separate from staff access.
The operations system is the staff workspace; the website is the client portal.